

Smishing Campaign Investigation: Fraudulent Indiana Traffic Enforcement QR Scam

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1. Incident Overview

On May 2, 2026, an unsolicited SMS message was received from the number +1 (978) 488-7005. The sender provided no accompanying text and instead delivered a professionally formatted image claiming to be an official State of Indiana traffic enforcement notice. The notice stated that the recipient was in active enforcement status for unresolved traffic violations and demanded immediate payment or mandatory court appearance. A QR code labeled Official Payment Portal was included to pressure the recipient into quick action. Due to the suspicious legal urgency, unsolicited delivery method, and payment request, the message was treated as a potential smishing attempt and investigated further.

2. Threat Classification

This threat was classified as a Government Impersonation Smishing Campaign utilizing QR-code phishing techniques. Unlike traditional phishing emails, this campaign relied on SMS delivery and an attached legal-looking image to create panic. The scam leveraged authority impersonation, urgency, fear of legal consequences, and immediate payment compliance. The inclusion of a QR code instead of a clickable hyperlink also demonstrates a modern evasion tactic, as QR images are less likely to be blocked by carrier spam filters and can bypass a user's instinct to inspect suspicious URLs manually.

3. Social Engineering Analysis

Several indicators were immediately present within the fraudulent notice. The image displayed the official seal of the State of Indiana and used authentic-looking Marion County court formatting to create false legitimacy. Language such as FINAL ENFORCEMENT NOTICE, COURT-ORDERED COMPLIANCE REQUIRED, and NO FURTHER NOTICES WILL BE ISSUED was designed to create a fear response and eliminate critical thinking time. The scam listed multiple broad violations to increase the likelihood that at least one accusation would feel believable. Finally, the QR code labeled Scan to Pay provided an urgent action point, steering the victim directly toward the attacker-controlled payment portal.

5. Technical Validation

Decoding the embedded QR code revealed the destination URL <https://etrn.popmartstoresale.com/public/ZeovEv>. This immediately confirmed the message was fraudulent because it did not resolve to any official Indiana government or court-owned domain. Instead, the QR code redirected to a suspicious third-party domain unrelated to any state judicial infrastructure. Additional open-source verification showed that Indiana law enforcement agencies recently issued public warnings about nearly identical traffic enforcement text scams circulating statewide, confirming this was part of a larger active smishing campaign rather than an isolated incident.

6. Risk Assessment

Had the QR code been scanned by an unsuspecting victim, the likely next stage would have involved a fraudulent payment or information submission portal requesting personal identifying information, mailing address, driver's license data, and debit or credit card payment details. This creates multiple risk layers including immediate financial theft, future identity fraud, and possible reuse of collected information for additional targeted phishing campaigns.

7. Defensive Recommendations

Recommended user actions include never scanning QR codes from unsolicited legal or financial text messages, verifying all citations or court notices directly through official government websites, reporting malicious numbers to carrier spam channels, and forwarding scam details to the Federal Trade Commission and state consumer protection authorities. This incident also demonstrates the need for broader user education on QR-based phishing, as many individuals are trained to avoid suspicious links but still trust visual QR payment prompts.

8. Conclusion

This investigation confirmed that the received SMS was part of an active QR-based government impersonation smishing campaign targeting Indiana residents. Through authority-based social engineering, legal urgency, and attacker-controlled payment redirection, the campaign attempted to coerce immediate victim compliance. QR code phishing continues to evolve beyond traditional text-link scams, making user awareness and rapid indicator validation increasingly important in defending against modern mobile threats.

4. Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

Sender Number	+1 (978) 488-7005
Threat Type	Government Impersonation Smishing
Delivery Vector	SMS image attachment
Fraudulent Case Number	49D06-TR-273196
Fraudulent Court Claim	Marion County Traffic Division
Embedded QR URL	etrn.popmartstoresale.com/public/ZeovEv
Root Domain	popmartstoresale.com
Payload Objective	Financial theft / PII harvesting